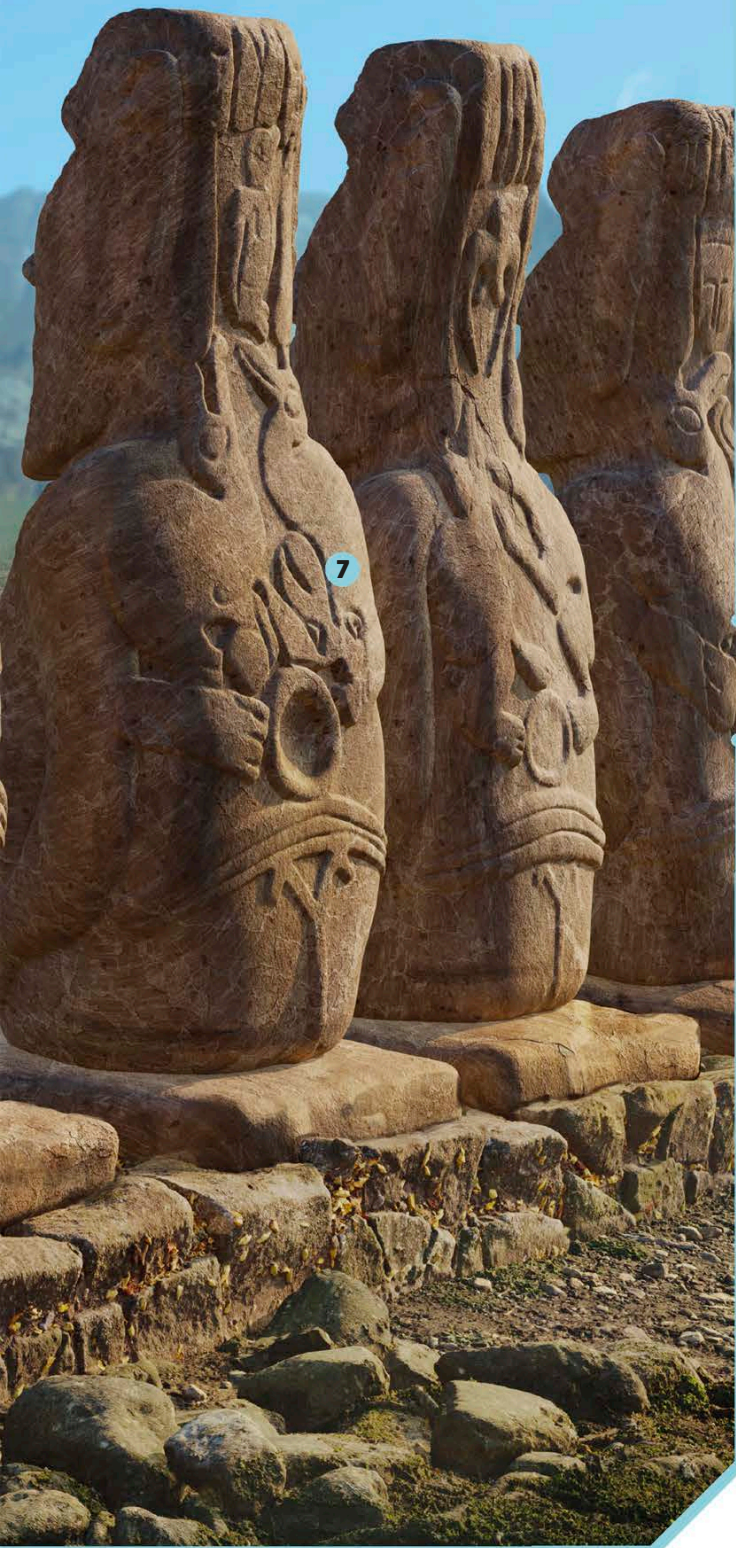


The giant statues at Rapa Nui weigh an average of 14 tons.

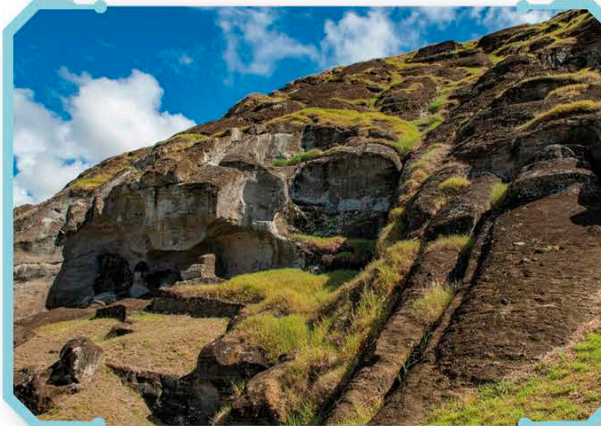


7 Carved backs
Patterns and animal- and birdlike figures are carved into the backs of each of the *moai* statues.

8 Volcanic rock
Rano Raraku crater, the source of the *moai* tuff, towers over the islanders as they work.

ERECTING THE MOAI

The islanders of Rapa Nui have one more *moai* to erect. They have already transported the statue across the island, using ropes to rock it from side to side to inch it forward, without lifting it off the ground. Now, they are straining to hoist it into position beside a row of finished *moai*. It's hot and heavy work!

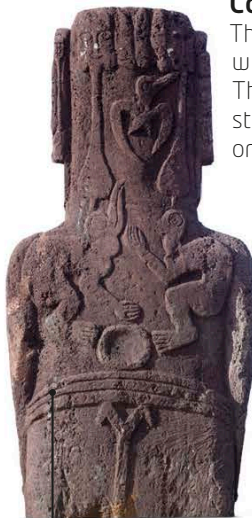


The quarry

Around 95 percent of the *moai* were carved in Rano Raraku quarry, from a porous volcanic rock called tuff. Each statue was made from a huge single piece of tuff. Nearly 400 *moai* statues still lie in the quarries where they were carved.

Complex carving

The *moais'* backs are decorated with figures called petroglyphs. The heads and fronts of the statues were carved as they lay on the ground, but their backs were finished after the statues had been lifted upright.



The canoe is a symbol of the carver's family.

Red *pukao*, or topknot

Red topknots

Some of the *moai* have a red *pukao*, or topknot. The *pukaos* are made from red scoria, a different rock from the tuff used for the bodies. The *moai* with *pukaos* are thought to be among the later statues carved.



Sweet potato payments

To obtain a statue, people would give a carver sweet potatoes, chickens, and tools. Sweet potatoes are originally from South America. The Polynesians would have sailed thousands of miles across the Pacific Ocean in order to bring the crop to Rapa Nui.

